



BIOGRAPHY

SAINT KATERI

Born in c. 1656 in present-day New York, Kateri Tekakwitha was the first Native American to be named a Catholic saint. A Mohawk woman raised by her uncle and the women of an Iroquoian longhouse, she was exposed to Christianity by French Jesuit missionaries. At 19, she converted to Catholicism and, in 1677, Kateri moved to a Christian Iroquois community in New France, where she took vows of chastity and self-mortification. Kateri died three years later, at 24, and was made a saint in 2012.

diplomacy with other Native Americans and European settlers. Within many Native cultures, women played a prominent role in their communities and tribes as political and spiritual leaders. In addition, many families within native societies were structured along matrilineal lines, meaning that they traced heritage and tribe membership through their mothers. This was true for members of the Iroquois Confederation, in which women also held the power to select men for (or remove them from) the position of chief.

Colonial society

In the first English settlements in North America, men vastly outnumbered women. As the colonies were founded as economic ventures, colonial leaders often struggled to entice women to become settlers, and the imbalance led to much instability within the early years of settlement. Settlers also had to contend with local Native American tribes, many of whom were displeased at the permanence of the colonies and waged war against the settlements. One solution was the marriage of Pocahontas—daughter of the powerful Chief Powhatan—to English settler John Rolfe, which improved the relationship between early settlers and the Powhatan Indians. Pocahontas converted to Christianity, taking the name Rebecca after her baptism, and learned the language and customs to assimilate to English culture, earning her the name “Tamed Savage of the West.”

▲ **Mixed relations**

Some colonists had relationships with native women, resulting in children, as shown in this image of 18th-century Mexico. This led to laws forbidding the taking of non-white brides.

A decade after its founding in 1607, the first British colony—Jamestown, Virginia—was struggling. The first two women to arrive in the colony had been Mrs. Forrest, a settler's wife, and her maid Anne Burras, who was to become the colony's first bride, in 1608. Yet the gender imbalance did not begin to tilt until the period from 1619 to 1621, when the Virginia company sent 150 women to the colonies as “maids to make wives.” The company theorized that bringing women to marry the male settlers would make the settlements more permanent, as people would start families there, and the men would also be more satisfied and therefore work harder.

Some women also came to the colonies under contracts as indentured servants, exchanging a few years of work for passage to the New World, and food, clothes, and shelter during their service. In New England, where colonies were formed by religious separatists, many migrated and settled as families, which made for a more equal gender balance from the start.

The status and roles of women varied throughout colonial America, influenced by factors such as race, religion, and geography. The continued dominance of patriarchy was questioned and challenged by women like

**“NOW HAVING SEEN ...
WHICH IS INVISIBLE I
FEAR NOT WHAT MAN
CAN DO UNTO ME.”**

ANNE HUTCHINSON'S TESTIMONY AT HER TRIAL, 1637